



Cloaking Charades: Make Your Web site Look Professional

In order to keep up the 'Professional' look of your Web site, you need to ensure that there is no trace of the 'free' hosts' domain. For example, let's say you host a free site at Geocities.com, and you WebForward your site from ZoneEdit to **www.geocities.com/thesiteyouwanttobuy/index.html** using the cloaked option. As visitors type thesiteyouwanttobuy.com in their browser, they are taken to **www.geocities.com/thesiteyouwanttobuy/index.html**, but the browser still shows thesiteyouwanttobuy.com. Unfortunately, you may have created a second page—a 'Products' page for example—called **products.html**, which is linked to from your site. The minute a visitor clicks on this link, he or she will be taken to **www.geocities.com/thesiteyouwanttobuy/products.html**. If the visitor looks up at his address bar, he will immediately know that this site is hosted for free at Geocities.com, thus spoiling the professional appeal you hoped for.

There is a simple way to counter this: edit or create your free Web site with a ZoneEdit window open. Whenever you want to link a page to another—say from **index.html** to **products.html**—just go to ZoneEdit and create a new WebForward for the sub-domain **products** (**products.thesiteyouwanttobuy.com**) and forward it with cloaking to **www.geocities.com/thesiteyouwanttobuy/products.html**. Now, in your **index.html** page, set the link as **products.thesiteyouwanttobuy.com**, and do not forget to upload the **products.html** page to Geocities.com.

If you do this for all the links to other pages in your Web site, you can pull off a pretty decent job of masquerading as a professionally hosted Web site.

For Tips on how to design a professional looking Web site, go through the tutorial from ImageOnline on the November 2004 Digit DVD and CD.

you can just click on ZoneEdit's trademark MailForward service and add, say, **sales@thesiteyouwanttobuy.com**, and forward it to **something@vsnl.net** for example.

Now, all e-mails sent to the domain's 'sales' e-mail alias will be forwarded to your VSNL account. You can do this for each employee and each service.

You can add as many e-mail aliases as you like, and even make your company seem a lot bigger than it is by adding aliases for 'customersupport', 'sales', 'production', 'dispatch', etc, all forwarding to a different or the same address.

You can even reply from these addresses if you have access to an SMTP server from your ISP. For details see the article

titled 'A Mailman for Your Business' (September 2004 Digit, page 102).

Free Web Sites

The easiest way to develop a professionally savvy Web site for your company is to use templates from Macromedia Dreamweaver or Microsoft Frontpage. You can also use your free host's quick site creation tool, such as Yahoo!'s PageBuilder.

We recommend using Dreamweaver and one of its templates. Remember to keep it simple with minimum graphics so that it loads quickly; this also helps you maintain a low bandwidth usage for your Web site—very important if your free host imposes per-day or per-hour bandwidth restrictions, the way Geocities.com does. The smaller

the size of each page, the faster it loads and the less bandwidth it uses up per visitor.

Remember to read through the box 'Cloaking Charades' when setting up internal page links in your Web site.

Now that you have set up your Web site, and have cloaked it to give it that professional look, do not forget to read up on search engine optimisation tips for your Web site. Nothing can get you more online business than being on one of the first three pages of a Google search for the product or service that you offer. Submit your site to Google by visiting **http://www.google.com/addurl.html**.

You can choose to use other services, however, try and get the best deal possible, and ensure that your domain is registered in your name—at times when you apply for a cheap hosting package, the registrar or hosting provider registers the domain in their name, thus forcing you to stick with them. Hence, do remember to read the fine print, both online and offline.

Our solution, use GoDaddy.com to register, ZoneEdit.com to manage DNS and Geocities.com to host for free, will cost you exactly \$8.95 (Rs 410) per year—just the cost of the domain name. All you need is a credit card, some free time and a little patience, and you can give your outfit a much needed edge.

Note that this solution cannot be compared to dedicated hosting and professional Web site development, but is merely a starting point for the millions of small Indian businesses or freelancing professionals, who can use all the help they can get. Happy Cloaking! ☒

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